

Looking to America for ideas

 **1** Write the missing vowels (a, e, i, o, u) to complete the information.

Bef__re World War II, Australia h__d a very strong c__nnection with Brit__in. After the w__r, it was Australia's c__nnection with the Unit__d St__tes that became stronger. When Japan became a threat during W__rld War II, Br__tain would not allow A__stralian troops to return from Europe to defend their co__ntry. It was the Un__ted States that provided m__litary support to Australi__.

Australia's connections with the Unit__d Stat__s were:

- **political** – similar valu__s and concerns about communism during the Cold War
- **military** – fighting c__nflicts together, such as the Vietn__m War
- **cultural** – Australians often preferred Am__rican movies and TV sh__ws to Australian and Brit__sh ones
- **social** – similar problems with r__cism and the way they treated diff__rent rac__al groups.

In the 1950s and 1960s, Afr__can-American groups began fighting for c__vil rights. The__r protests were broadcast throug__ut the world and the whole world w__tched. Ind__genous Australi__n civil r__ghts groups paid close att__ntion to the ways that the Afric__n-American pe__ple protested. They used m__ny of these ideas in their own f__ght for civil rights.

2 Write the ways of protesting from the word bank beside the correct definition.

Word bank	court cases	Freedom Rides	marches	petitions	sit-ins
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Ways of protesting

- _____: Large groups of people walked down streets to get attention.
- _____: Going on bus trips to challenge segregation in the facilities at bus stations
- _____: Using the legal system to fight for land rights and civil rights
- _____: Writing a letter about civil rights and getting lots of people to sign it
- _____: Peacefully sitting in places that people of their race are not supposed to be

3 What ways of protesting do people use today? Are they effective? Why?

List your ideas in your workbook.

Freedom Rides

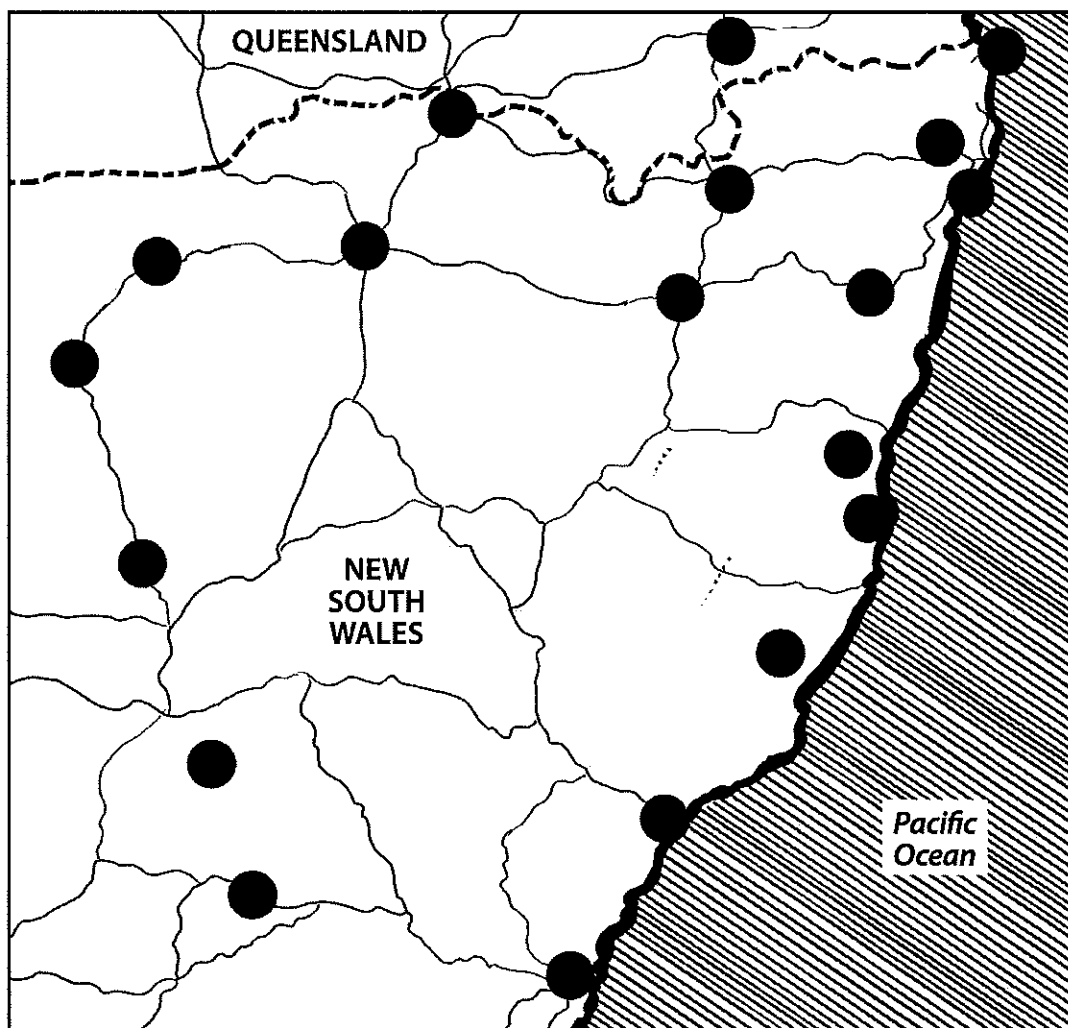
In 1965, a group of students from the University of Sydney formed a group called Student Action For Aborigines (SAFA). They decided to follow the example of American civil rights activists and go on their own Freedom Rides. They hired a bus and travelled around New South Wales to see for themselves how Indigenous Australian people were treated. When they saw discrimination, they would protest about it.

In many places, Indigenous Australian people were banned from swimming pools, refused service in shops and cafes and kept out of RSL (Returned Service Leagues) clubs, despite serving in wars

 **1** Label the places in the box on the map. Use an atlas or the internet to help.

Then draw the route the Freedom Riders followed.

Route of the Freedom Riders



Freedom Ride stops, in order of travel

- Sydney
- Orange
- Wellington
- Gulgambone
- Walgett
- Collarenebri
- Moree
- Boggabilla
- Warwick
- Tenterfield
- Glen Innes
- Grafton
- Lismore
- Bowraville
- Kempsey
- Cabbage Tree Island
- Taree
- Newcastle
- Sydney

2 In your workbook, explain why you think the Freedom Riders chose these destinations. In what ways are they similar?

Charles Perkins and Ann Curthoys

Charles Perkins and Ann Curthoys were Arts students at the University of Sydney when they took part in the Freedom Rides. Ann wrote a diary about her experiences on the rides. Charles, one of only two Indigenous Australian students at the university, later wrote an autobiography. On 15 February 1965, the Freedom Riders reached Walgett. After meeting with Wayilwan and Gamilaraay people, the riders decided to protest at the Walgett Returned Services Leagues (RSL) club. This club refused to allow Indigenous Australians to join, even if they had been in the armed services.



Charles Perkins interviews Aboriginal people, Mitchell Library, State Library of NSW. Courtesy of the SEARCH Foundation.



Ann Curthoys (left) and Louise Higham (centre) interview residents at Moree Aboriginal Station, Mitchell Library, State Library of NSW. Courtesy of the SEARCH Foundation.

All the members of the RSL had to pass right past us and they read the banners. They either laughed at us or spat at us or on the banners. Some of them got banners and tore them up. Some of the local smarties wanted to bash a few of us up. They said, 'You're stirring up trouble. The dirty niggers* don't deserve any better and they are happy how they are.'

Extract from Charles Perkins, *A Bastard Like Me*, Ure Smith, 1975.

With permission of the Perkins family.

*'Nigger' in this context is a historical term and very much outdated in usage. It was highly offensive at the time and still is today.

Its use here clearly demonstrates a shift since 1965 in the language and actions that society believes are acceptable. The actual origin of the word is from the Latin *niger*, meaning black.

We just stood in a long line outside the RSL holding placards like
"Acceptance, Not Segregation"
"End Colour Bar"
"Bullets did not Discriminate"
"Walgett - Australia's Disgrace"
"Why Whites Only"
"Educate the Whites"
and so on.

People gathered round, many jeering, many just watching ... At lunchtime many heated discussions broke out. Charlie Perkins spoke terrifically and I think most people listened very attentively. As time went on, more and more aborigines joined in the discussions."

Extract from Ann Curthoys' diary from the 1965 Freedom Rides.

With permission of Ann Curthoys.

